



EDUCATION ABROAD PROGRAM

External and Affiliated Program Approvals

INTRODUCTION

Establishing education abroad partnerships between institutions and organizations requires clear communication and transparency of responsibilities. It also must have mutual benefit. A clear review and approval process enables institutions to meaningfully assess programs approved for credit and financial aid transfer, and it ensures compliance with accreditation and federal funding guidelines. The following template is informed by the [Standards of Good Practice in Education Abroad](#) and can be adapted into agreement templates specific to your own institutional needs.

STANDARDS REFERENCED:

4. GUIDING PRINCIPLES

4.1. MISSION AND GOALS

- 4.1.1. Responsible parties shall ensure that educational objectives are central to program design and implementation and that the objectives support the mission and goals.

4.4. EQUITY, DIVERSITY, AND INCLUSION

- 4.4.5. Each organization shall establish meaningful contacts and connections with diverse partners, employ and enroll diverse participants, and foster inclusive communities.
- 4.4.6. Each organization should design its programs to provide opportunities for students to interact with broadly diverse peers, personnel, and members of local communities.

5. ADMINISTRATIVE FRAMEWORK

5.1. POLICIES, PROCEDURES, AND GUIDELINES:

Each organization shall define policies, procedures, and guidelines to govern its programs and practices and prepare its personnel to apply them.

5.1.4. Each organization shall have procedures facilitating program administration, including but not limited to:

- Program proposal and approval process [...]
- Regular review of ongoing programs

5.1.8. Each organization should have guidelines governing its partnerships, including but not limited to:

- Establishing partnerships and formalizing collaboration [...]
- Partnership review

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

[Guidelines for Good Business Partnerships in Education Abroad, Second Edition](#)

[Code of Ethics for Education Abroad, 3rd edition](#)

PROGRAM APPROVAL PROCESS

1. Identify the oversight committee and those responsible for making decisions on curriculum.
2. Review program details to ensure program goals and curriculum are aligned with institutional goals and curriculum.
3. Gather support from appropriate stakeholders, which may include but not be limited to:
 - a. Colleges, academic department chairs, or deans
 - b. Business and administrative offices
 - c. Risk managers
 - d. Students
4. Secure endorsement from relevant senior administrators.
5. Provide detailed information to oversight committee/decision makers:
 - a. Program description
 - i. Overview of organization: history, mission, and goals
 1. Host institution/School of Record
 2. Program type: direct enrollment, third party, exchange, virtual?
 3. Terms offered
 - ii. Program structure
 1. Typical credit load
 2. Prerequisites (language proficiency, program determined GPA expectations, academic standing, class-year standing, etc.)
 3. Housing arrangements
 4. Co-curricular opportunities
 - iii. Academics and curriculum
 1. Majors/minors
 2. Sample course descriptions and possible equivalents
 - iv. Financial information (tuition, housing, fees) in relation to the institutional financial model for education abroad
 1. Availability of scholarships
 - v. Location
 1. Risk assessment (travel alerts, security assessment)
 2. Does the location contribute to a diverse portfolio of education abroad programs?
 - b. History of engagement with the organization or program
 - c. List of peer and aspirational institutions that also approve the program, accompanied by an endorsement, if possible.
 - d. Organizational affiliations:
 - i. Is the program run by a member of The Forum on Education Abroad?
 - ii. Other organizational affiliations?
6. Secure approval from the oversight committee/decision makers.
7. Initiate Memoranda of Understanding or Agreement with the program.
8. Schedule approval timeline.

PROGRAM APPROVAL FORM TEMPLATE

Program Name: _____

Location: _____

Type of Program:

- ☐ Direct Enroll
- ☐ International Education Organization
- ☐ Exchange
- ☐ Virtual

Terms: _____

School of Record (who provides the grade report or transcript): _____

Overview of Partner Institution/Organization:

Program Structure:

- Terms available (semester, quarter, summer) _____
- Typical course load per term _____
- Availability of curricular and co-curricular activities (internships, community-based learning, research, excursions)

- Are students taking classes with local students, a mix of local and international students, or exclusively international students?

Academics/Curriculum:

- Prerequisites for admissions (GPA, courses, language proficiency, research experience)

- Courses offered and descriptions

- Academic alignment with home institution

Financial Information:

- Program fees (tuition, housing, additional fees)

- Available scholarships (internal and external)

- Affordability for student population

Location Risk Assessment:

- Travel Advisory ratings (U.S. State Department or equivalent ministry, Overseas Security Advisory Council (OSAC), World Health Organization, etc.)

- Security services assessment (if available)

- Insurance coverage

- Infrastructure (availability of health care services, communication, road safety)

- Current media coverage

Rationale for Addition of Program:

- How does this program meet institutional strategic goals and/or curricular outcomes?

- Does it improve the diversity of the institution's portfolio of programs?

- Is it in response to requests from students and/or faculty?

Historical and Future Engagement:

- When and how has the home institution engaged with the prospective partner?

- How often?

- Is there a site visit planned soon? Who will visit?

College or Department Endorsement:

- Which departments or faculty endorse this program for approval?

- Is there supporting documentation?

Peer/Aspirational Partnerships:

- List agreements or affiliations with peer or aspirational institutions

- Provide referrals to support your proposal

Affiliations:

- Is the partner organization affiliated with any organizations that advocate for quality education abroad programs (The Forum, NAFSA, Diversity Abroad, etc.)?
